



Windows Phone is officially dead

Microsoft's Joe Belfiore has revealed on Twitter that Windows Phone will not see any further hardware and feature updates. <http://digit.in/RIPMSPhone>



Facebook StarCraft bot comes 6th

CherryPi, designed by folks affiliated with Facebook's AI, competed in the StarCraft bot-on-bot challenge and came 6th. <http://digit.in/FBAicomp>



At your Service

All about India's hyperlocal service segment - what works and how, and where is it headed?

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hat if your door lock breaks tonight when you try to enter/leave your place? Or maybe you pull the sink

faucet right off the wall and your house gets flooded? Or maybe you're being plagued by a malfunctioning light? Even if none of the above happen to you, there are quite a few situations where you need to employ professional services at your home/workplace, especially on an on-demand basis. Not too long ago, you would have picked up

your copy of the yellow pages, rang up your building watchman or harnessed your own repository of curated contacts to get the right serviceman. Today, there's an app for that.

In fact, there are quite a few apps and services offering you hyperlocal, curated service professionals at your doorsteps as and when you need them. Their services range across the examples we talked about above and more. And with the huge range of services, comes the confusion towards which one to use. We try figuring out what

really works in India when it comes to these services.

THE LEVEL FIELD

It's important to understand what most of these services have in common. For instance, regardless of the service model and monetisation, almost every single one of these service providers boasts a roster of personally verified professionals, with background checks and police verifications done. Another similarity is their involvement in several verticals - be it beauty, plumbing, household help etc. And that's pretty much where the segment wide similarities end. Sure, while availing a service you may not find noticeable differences, but there's a lot that goes on under the hood that acts as a differentiator.



Urbanclap is one of the most well known names in this segment

DISCOVERY VS ONBOARDING

The discovery of services around you is what puts the 'local' in hyperlocal. That's why every one of these services gets your location first. Urbanclap, which started in 2014, began as a search and discovery platform, something that competitors like Hometrangle still define themselves as. The advantage here is mainly to the service professional, who gets to maintain his brand identity as well as the flexibility to quote what he/she deems suitable remuneration for the services offered. On the other hand, the customer also gets to choose between different price points for the same service. Cheep is a good example of a discovery service offering the flexibility of choice between different professionals based on their quotes, experience, ratings etc.

Onboarding, on the other hand, is when a service discovery platform, like Urbanclap, takes on the role of a service provider itself. Professionals are on-boarded and trained according to company standards and fixed rates are charged for their services. This way, the